

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Romans 1:1

slave of Christ Jesus: The word *slave* is used of important Old Testament leaders of God's people, such as Moses ([2 Kgs 18:12](#)), Joshua ([Josh 24:29](#)), Elijah ([2 Kgs 10:10](#)), and David ([2 Sam 7:8](#)). The title underscores Paul's complete subservience to Christ as Lord. • sent out (literally *set apart*): Paul may be alluding to being set apart by God for his mission before he was born, as the prophet Jeremiah was ([Jer 1:5](#)). He may also be referring to God's call at the time of his Damascus Road conversion ([Acts 9:15-16](#); cp. [Acts 13:2](#)), to preach the Good News to Jews and especially to Gentiles. • The Good News, or "gospel," is a recurrent topic in the opening of the letter ([Rom 1:1, 9, 15, 16](#)). Paul takes the word from the Old Testament, where the Hebrew equivalent refers to the victory that God wins for his people ([Isa 40:9](#); [41:27](#); [60:6](#); [61:1](#); [Nah 1:15](#); see [Joel 2:32](#)).

Romans 1:1-17

These verses contain the normal features of New Testament letter introductions: an identification of the writer ([1:1-6](#)) and readers ([1:7](#)), a thanksgiving ([1:8-15](#)), and the theme of the letter ([1:16-17](#)).

Romans 1:3

In his earthly life (literally *As regards the flesh*): Paul often uses "flesh" (Greek *sarx*) to refer to bodily existence in this world (e.g., [4:1](#); [8:3](#)). • Paul refers to King David's family line because God promised that a descendant of David would be the Messiah and would be given an eternal kingdom ([2 Sam 7:13-16](#); see [Isa 9:7](#); [Jer 33:15](#)). Jesus was born into David's line ([Matt 1:6](#); [Luke 1:27, 32](#)), so he was qualified to fulfill God's promise.

Romans 1:3-4

In the Greek, these verses are in carefully structured parallel form; Paul might be quoting an early Christian creed or hymn about Jesus Christ as

God's Son in order to establish common ground with the Roman Christians, whom he had never visited.

Romans 1:4

he was shown to be: Although Jesus eternally existed as the Son of God ([1:3](#)), his resurrection demonstrated him to be God's Son, revealing him in all his power and glory.

Romans 1:5

given us . . . apostles: Here Paul might have been thinking both of himself and of the other apostles, or he might be using an editorial plural to refer only to himself. • Privilege and authority could specify two separate things, but one might explain the other, as in the privilege of having apostolic authority. Paul always makes it clear that his distinctive authority is a gift from God (see also [15:15-16](#)). • so that they will believe and obey him: This summary of Paul's purpose in preaching to Gentiles brackets the book of Romans, as he repeats the same idea in slightly different language at the end of the letter ([16:26](#)). Paul wanted Gentiles to believe in Jesus Christ; he underscored that believing in Jesus Christ as the Lord entails a commitment to obey him. Faith and obedience are not identical, but one does not occur without the other.

Romans 1:7

To be holy means to be set apart for God. This expression is used throughout the Old Testament to describe Israel, God's chosen people (cp. [Exod 19:6](#)), whom God called from among all other nations to be his own. By calling the Gentile Christians his own holy people, Paul makes it clear that Gentiles are now fully included among God's people.

Romans 1:9

When Paul uses the phrase with all my heart (or *in my spirit*), he might be describing the influence of God's Holy Spirit on his own inner person. The word *spirit* also refers to the deepest part of a person, which the phrase *all my heart* expresses well.

Romans 1:11

some spiritual gift: Paul is probably referring to the spiritual benefit that he hopes his ministry will bring to the Roman Christians.

Romans 1:13

brothers and sisters: This Greek word (*adelphoi*) describes people who are in a familial relationship. Paul and other New Testament writers use this word to indicate that Christians are so intimately tied to one another in Christ that they are family. The word refers to both male and female Christians. • I was prevented until now: Paul wrote this letter when he was in Corinth toward the end of his third missionary journey (see [Acts 20:2-4](#); cp. [Rom 16:21-23](#)). The need to plant and nourish churches in the eastern Mediterranean had occupied Paul up to this point. Before he could visit the Roman Christians, he first needed to return to Jerusalem to deliver a gift of money collected from the Gentile churches for the impoverished Jewish Christians ([15:23-29](#)).

Romans 1:14

to people in both the civilized world and the rest of the world (literally *to Greeks and barbarians*): The Greeks prided themselves on being sophisticated and cultured, while regarding people from other cultures as inferior. They mocked other peoples' poorly spoken Greek, claiming that they could only say "bar bar," a nonsense phrase from which our word *barbarian* comes. Paul uses this cultural divide to emphasize his intention to preach the Good News to all kinds of people.

Romans 1:16

The apostle Paul often emphasizes that the *gospel* (the good news about Jesus) is for *everyone*. He also insists that God first chose the Jews to be his people. God made promises to them and gave them a unique role in his continuing plan ([3:1-8](#); [9:1-5](#)). They have a special responsibility to respond to the gospel. They will experience God's judgment first if they reject the gospel ([2:9-10](#)).

Romans 1:17

how God makes us right in his sight (literally *the righteousness of God*): This key phrase appears eight times in Romans (see also [3:5](#), [21](#), [22](#), [25](#), [26](#); [10:3](#); the only other occurrence in Paul's writings is [2 Cor 5:21](#)). The expression has Old Testament roots, where God's righteousness refers to his character (as holy or faithful) or to an act of declaring his people sinless and perfect in his eyes (see especially [Isa 46:13](#); [51:5-8](#)). Paul uses the second meaning in this verse. The Good News has the power to save because it is the fulfillment of God's promise to vindicate his people. • The phrase makes us right comes from the law court. It does not mean "makes us good people"; it means "puts us in right standing before God." • "It is through faith that a righteous person has life": The prophet Habakkuk had struggled to understand how God could use pagan nations to judge his own people Israel. God reminded Habakkuk that his true people—the *righteous*—need to live by faith ([Hab 2:4](#)). In [Rom 1-4](#), Paul repeatedly insists that only through faith can human beings be made right in God's sight.

Romans 1:18

God's anger is not a spontaneous emotional outburst, but the holy God's necessary response to sin. The Old Testament often depicts God's anger ([Exod 32:10-12](#); [Num 11:1](#); [Jer 21:3-7](#)) and predicts a decisive outpouring of God's wrath on human sin at the end of history. While Paul usually depicts God's anger as occurring in the end times ([Rom 2:5, 8](#); [5:9](#); [Col 3:6](#); [1 Thes 1:10](#)), the present tense of shows refers to God's expressions of anger throughout human history.

Romans 1:18–3:20

Paul delays exploring the theme of righteousness through faith (see [3:21](#)) until after he first teaches about universal sinfulness. Gentiles ([1:18–32](#)) and Jews ([2:1–3:8](#)) are equally under sin's power and cannot find favor with God by any action of their own ([3:9–20](#)).

Romans 1:21

To *know God* in Scripture usually means to have an intimate, saving relationship with him (see [2 Cor 5:16](#); [Gal 4:9](#); [Phil 3:8, 10](#)). Here, however, they knew God means that people knew about God. All people have some understanding of God through creation, yet they do not do what is right based on that knowledge. Rather than learn more about God, they worship gods of their own making.

Romans 1:24

When people replaced the living God with idols (false gods), God abandoned them. Paul emphasizes this point twice more in this paragraph ([1:26, 28](#)). The phrase *gave them over* suggests that God actively allows people to experience the consequences of their sin.

Romans 1:26

women turned against the natural way: In this context, *natural way* refers to the nature of the world as God made it. As in the Old Testament, Paul singles out homosexuality as a key illustration of how people have fallen away from worship of the true God (see [Gen 19:1–28](#); [Lev 18:22](#); [20:13](#); [Deut 23:17–18](#)). God created human beings as male and female, and engaging in homosexual activity is a violation of God's creative intention.

Romans 1:27

suffered within themselves the penalty they deserved: When people abandon the Creator's intentions, they are judged for their actions. This judgment can take many different forms, but the ultimate consequence is spiritual death (see [1:32](#)).

Romans 1:28

thought it foolish: Sin affects our actions and even our thoughts. One of the serious consequences of turning away from God is an unsound mind; people can no longer use their minds as God intended.

Romans 1:29–31

This list of sins follows a popular Hellenistic literary form called a *vice list*. While not exhaustive, it reminds readers of various forms that evil might take.

Romans 1:32

To encourage others to sin is worse than sinning oneself ([Jas 3:1](#); cp. *Testament of Asher* 6:2: "The two-faced are doubly punished because they both practice evil and approve of others who practice it; they imitate the spirits of error and join in the struggle against mankind").

Romans 2:1–5

You is singular in the Greek. Here, the *you* is a hypothetical complacent Jew, who feels superior to Gentiles and in no danger of judgment. Paul adopts a popular Hellenistic style called a *diatribe*, in which a writer tries to win over an audience to his views by portraying a debate between himself and a hypothetical opponent. • these very same things: Paul's point is that Jews, like Gentiles, turn from God's revelation to go their own way.

Romans 2:4

Can't you see that his kindness is intended to turn you from your sin? Behind Paul's question are Jewish passages (e.g., *Wisdom of Solomon* 12–15; cp. [Jer 7:1–5](#); [Amos 5:18–27](#)) that portray a prevalent Jewish complacency toward judgment. Many Jews thought that because they were God's people, they did not need to worry about judgment, for their sins would not be punished as the sins of Gentiles would be. Paul emphasizes that God's grace was intended to turn the Jews from their sin, not to condone a sinful lifestyle.

Romans 2:6–11

Paul uses a *chiasm* (“X” arrangement) to make his point:

A God judges everyone the same ([2:6](#))

B Life is the reward for doing good ([2:7](#))

C Wrath is the penalty for evil ([2:8](#))

C’ Wrath for doing evil ([2:9](#))

B’ Life for doing good ([2:10](#))

A’ God shows no favoritism ([2:11](#))

Romans 2:7

He will give eternal life to those who keep on doing good: Paul makes it clear elsewhere that no one can receive eternal life except as God’s gift through faith ([3:20](#), [28](#); [4:1–8](#)). Here, Paul is either referring to Christians whose good deeds (that result from faith) will be taken into account in God’s judgment, or he is reminding readers of the absolute standard that God’s own holiness establishes, since only by perfection can sinners hope to find acceptance before God. As the argument of the letter unfolds, Paul will show that no one is capable of meeting that standard.

Romans 2:8

Live for themselves translates a rare Greek word (*eritheia*) that seems to convey the idea of selfish ambition or strife. Using this word, Aristotle scolded the politicians of his day for seeking public office for selfish gain rather than from a desire to serve the people (Aristotle, *Politics* 5.3; see also [2 Cor 12:20](#); [Gal 5:20](#); [Phil 1:17](#); [2:3](#); [Jas 3:14](#), [16](#)).

Romans 2:12

destroyed: This common New Testament word describes the fate of the wicked after death (see also [9:22](#); [14:15](#); [1 Cor 1:18](#); [15:18](#); [2 Cor 2:15](#); [4:3](#); [Phil 1:28](#); [3:19](#); [2 Thes 2:10](#); [1 Tim 6:9](#)). Condemned sinners do not cease to exist, but they suffer eternal punishment, which includes the everlasting destruction of all good in their identity and experience. • the Jews, who do have God’s law: The Jews were given the law of Moses, while the Gentiles never had God’s written law. In the New

Testament period, Jews emphasized their possession of the law as a mark of God’s favor and even as a guarantee of salvation.

Romans 2:13

obeying the law . . . makes us right in his sight: Regarding the promise of righteousness through obedience, see [2:7](#); see also [Jas 1:22](#).

Romans 2:14–15

The Gentiles who know his law when they instinctively obey it may be Gentile Christians, especially since written in their hearts ([2:15](#)) alludes to the prophecy of the new covenant ([Jer 31:31–34](#)). Or they could be non-Christian Gentiles who know God’s general moral law through their consciences. In this case, Paul would be using the notion of *natural law* to show how all people could be held accountable for certain basic moral requirements.

Romans 2:16

secret life (literally *the hidden things*): Scripture frequently stresses that God will judge people according to their thoughts and intentions (see [1 Sam 16:7](#); [Ps 139:1–2](#); [Jer 17:10](#)).

Romans 2:17–20

The boasting of the Jews reflects Old Testament and Jewish teaching about the privileges and responsibilities God gave to Israel. God gave his law to Israel, entered into a special relationship with them, and commissioned them to be a light to the Gentiles (see [Isa 42:6–7](#)). Jews were not wrong to enjoy these blessings; their error was in failing to live up to their privileged position.

Romans 2:21–22

Paul again uses the diatribe style to expose the inconsistency of Jewish claims (see study note on [2:1–5](#)).

Romans 2:22

do you use items stolen from pagan temples? Old Testament law prohibited Jews from having anything to do with pagan idols (see [Deut 7:26](#)), but first-century Jews did not strictly follow this law. Sometimes they stole idols and used or sold the precious metals.

Romans 2:24

Paul quotes [Isa 52:5](#), where God's name is blasphemed because Israel is oppressed by pagan nations. Here, Paul uses that passage to demonstrate the failure of the Jews to live up to their responsibilities.

Romans 2:25

God instituted the Jewish ceremony of circumcision as a sign of his covenant with Abraham; it was to be performed on every male Israelite child ([Gen 17:9-13](#); see [Rom 4:11](#)). Circumcision therefore represents God's covenant with his people Israel. The rite took on greater significance during the intertestamental period when the pagan king Antiochus IV Epiphanes tried to stamp out the Jewish faith by forbidding circumcision and other Jewish practices. The Jews resisted in the famous Maccabean Revolt (166–160 BC). After they restored the worship of the Lord in Israel, the Jews regarded circumcision as a highly prized mark of Jewish loyalty in the midst of a pagan culture.

Romans 2:26

won't God declare them to be his own people? Paul might be speaking of Gentile Christians who are God's people because they obey God's law, or he could be speaking hypothetically about what would happen if a Gentile perfectly obeyed God's law.

Romans 2:29

The letter of the law refers to the law of God written on tablets of stone (see [2 Cor 3:3](#)), while the Spirit now writes his law on people's hearts ([Jer 31:33-34](#)). Outward conformity is thus contrasted with obedience motivated by a change of heart.

Romans 3:1

what's the advantage of being a Jew? Paul moves his argument along by raising questions. After preaching the Good News for over twenty years, he knew what questions people would ask when they heard a particular teaching. His emphasis on the equality of Jews and Gentiles before God (ch [2](#)) inevitably led people to ask whether he was eliminating all Jewish privileges. The question-and-answer style follows the pattern of the diatribe (see study note on 2:1–5).

Romans 3:2

The advantage that Jews possessed was in having received God's word. • First of all: Paul never adds a second or a third point to the list he begins here. He might have forgotten to continue the list, or *first of all* might mean "most importantly." However, [9:4–5](#) provides a good indication of what a list of Jewish privileges would have included. • By using the word revelation (Greek *logia*, "oracles, messages"), Paul highlights God's personal communication with his people (see [Deut 33:9](#); [Ps 105:19](#)) through which he gives them special privileges and responsibilities.

Romans 3:4

Of course not! The Greek *mē genoito* is an emphatic negation, popular in the diatribe style that Paul uses here and in several other passages in Romans (see [3:6, 31](#); [6:2, 15](#); [7:7, 13](#); [9:14](#); [11:1, 11](#)). • As the Scriptures say: Paul quotes [Ps 51:4](#), where David confessed his sin in having an adulterous relationship with Bathsheba (see [2 Sam 11:1–27](#)). God punished David, and David admitted that God was proved right and would win his case in court—his punishment was entirely just. God is faithful to what he has said in the past—his entire revelation—and his words warn of punishment for sin even as they promise reward for obedience.

Romans 3:5–7

how would he be qualified to judge the world? Abraham asked a similar question: "Should not the Judge of all the earth do what is right?" ([Gen 18:25](#)).

God punishes all sin, and he retains absolute righteousness as he does so. Even when God makes use of human sin for his own ends, that sin still deserves to be, and will be, punished (see [Rom 9:10-24](#)).

Romans 3:8

some people even slander us: Paul is referring to misrepresentations about his teaching on justification by faith. If a person is made right with God by faith alone, through God's grace and apart from works, it could seem as if the Good News allows believers to sin because their sin is forgiven when confessed (see [6:1](#)). One of Paul's purposes is to help the Roman Christians understand that such misunderstandings are without basis.

Romans 3:9

No, not at all: Paul's emphatic answer does not contradict his claim in [3:1-2](#) that Jews have an advantage. But that advantage has not done them any good because they have disobeyed God's word and incurred God's punishment. Jews, like Gentiles, have sinned against the revelation of God and stand condemned. • under the power of sin (literally *under sin*): Being "under" something carries the sense of being under its power. The ultimate problem of human beings is not the fact of sin, but the situation of being slaves to sin. The solution to this problem requires the liberation provided in Christ Jesus, who frees us from both the penalty and the power of sin.

Romans 3:10-12

This quotation from [Pss 14:1-3](#); [53:1-3](#) directly supports the argument that all people are under the power of sin.

Romans 3:10-18

The six quotations in these verses, drawn from various parts of the Old Testament, all address human sinfulness. Paul follows the practice of rabbis who gathered together Old Testament texts on similar themes in a practice called *pearl-stringing*.

Romans 3:13-14

Paul here refers to sins of speech, mentioning a different organ of speech in each of the four lines (talk in [3:13](#) is literally *throat*).

Romans 3:15-17

In this quotation from [Isa 59:7-8](#), Paul addresses sins against others.

Romans 3:18

They have no . . . : This concluding quotation from [Ps 36:1](#) neatly ties up the whole series ([Rom 3:10-18](#)) by referring to the same Greek words that introduced the first quotation (*ouk estin*, translated in [3:10](#), "No one is").

Romans 3:19

Paul speaks of the entire Old Testament as the law (see also [1 Cor 9:8, 9](#); [14:21, 34](#); [Gal 4:21](#)). • Those to whom it was given (literally *those in the law*) were the Jews, who were given the Scriptures. • How can Paul conclude that the entire world is guilty before God on the basis of evidence from the Old Testament that Jews are sinful? He argues from the greater to the lesser, a standard Jewish rhetorical technique: If the law shows that the Jews, God's own people, are guilty, then how much more are the Gentiles, who have not had the benefit of God's instruction, also guilty.

Romans 3:20

By doing what the law commands refers to obeying the requirements of the law of Moses. While this phrase refers to Jews, the principle extends to all people. If Jews cannot be put in right relationship with God by obeying the law God gave them, certainly other people cannot establish such a relationship through good deeds.

Romans 3:21–22

After a lengthy reminder of the power of sin ([1:18–3:20](#)), Paul returns to the theme presented in [1:17](#), the way to be made right with God (literally *the righteousness of God*). As in that verse, “the righteousness of God” is the way that God puts people in right relationship with himself. • without keeping the requirements of the law (literally *apart from the law*): The old covenant looked forward to the climactic revelation of God’s righteousness in his Son. Because of what God has accomplished for us in Christ by completely fulfilling the requirements of the law, we are now able to come to him by faith, apart from the covenant structure set up by the law of Moses (cp. [Heb 8:13](#)).

Romans 3:21–4:25

Paul returns to the central theme of the righteousness of God that is revealed in Christ and is available to anyone who believes. The fundamental statement of this theology is in [3:21–26](#); Paul elaborates on it in [3:27–31](#) and illustrates it with the experience of Abraham in ch [4](#).

Romans 3:24

God, in his grace: God makes us right in his sight, not because he has to, but because he has freely chosen to give us his favor through Christ Jesus. Because we are helpless slaves of sin ([3:9](#)), our righteous status before God can never be earned (see [4:4–5](#)). • through Christ Jesus when he freed us from the penalty for our sins (literally *through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus*): In Paul’s day, *redemption* referred to the price paid to free a slave. God paid our redemption price with the blood of his own Son to rescue us from our slavery to sin (see [3:9](#)). This language was used in the Old Testament to refer to the Exodus, the first redemption of God’s people from bondage (see [2 Sam 7:23](#)). God promised that he would again redeem his people ([Hos 13:14](#); [Mic 4:10](#)).

Romans 3:25

the sacrifice for sin (Greek *hilastērion*): This Greek word is used in the Greek Old Testament to refer to the “atonement cover,” the cover that rested on the Ark of the Covenant in the inner sanctuary of the

Tabernacle. The atonement cover was prominent in the Day of Atonement ritual ([Lev 16](#)) and came to stand for the atonement ceremony itself. Paul characterizes Jesus Christ as God’s provision of final atonement for his people. Jesus himself satisfies, or absorbs in himself, the anger of God against all sinful people (see [Rom 1:18](#)). • those who sinned in times past: Paul refers to righteous Old Testament people who were not punished for their sins as strict justice would require. Hebrews reminds us, “it is not possible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins” ([Heb 10:4](#)). How, then, could God forgive people in the Old Testament? Paul answers that Jesus’ sacrifice works backward in history as well as forward—through Christ, God provided for the full satisfaction of his righteous anger against human sin.

Romans 3:29–30

Paul uses the foundational Jewish commitment to monotheism to argue for universal access to God’s forgiveness. If there is only one God, then he is equally the God of both Jews and Gentiles. All people must be able to come to God on the same terms, through faith.

Romans 3:31

we truly fulfill the law: Paul knows that some people will object to his insistence on faith apart from the law because it seems to dismiss the demands of the law. However, faith actually enables people to fulfill the law. The Holy Spirit is given to those who have faith, and he makes it possible for people to do as they should.

Romans 4:1

Jews in Paul’s day revered Abraham as Israel’s founder. Some Jewish texts claim that Abraham never sinned (*Prayer of Manasseh* 8; *Jubilees* 23:10). Others emphasize his obedience to the law of Moses as the basis for his relationship with God (*1 Maccabees* 2:52; *Sirach* 44:19–20). However, Paul demonstrates that Abraham’s faith, not his obedience, established his status with God. Abraham’s position as the founder of God’s people demonstrates that justification by faith is central in God’s plan.

Romans 4:3

Paul quotes [Gen 15:6](#). In response to God's promise that he would have descendants as numerous as the stars in the sky, Abraham believed God. It was faith that established Abraham's relationship with God—not works ([Rom 4:3-8](#)), circumcision ([4:9-12](#)), the law ([4:13-17](#)), or the number of his descendants ([4:18-21](#)).

Romans 4:4-5

The logic of these verses is as follows: (1) The stated premise is that when people work, their pay is what they have earned, not a gift. (2) The unstated premise is that God is never indebted to his creatures (because they owe him everything), so anything he gives them is a gift (see also [9:14-16](#)). (3) The conclusion is that therefore, people cannot be declared righteous before God because of their works.

Romans 4:7-8

This quotation from [Ps 32:1-2](#) follows the Jewish custom of supporting a reference to the Law with a reference in the Prophets or the Writings. Paul also uses a Jewish exegetical technique of linking unrelated quotations with a key word. Here, record ... has cleared translates the same Greek word as "counted" in [Rom 4:3](#).

Romans 4:10

God accepted Abraham before he was circumcised! Paul's point is simple: God's declaration of Abraham's righteousness in [Gen 15:6](#) could not have been based on his circumcision, which happened later ([Gen 17](#)). This point further demonstrates that God's acceptance and blessing is a free gift and not earned by works.

Romans 4:11-12

When God instituted circumcision, he called it "a sign of the covenant" between himself and Abraham ([Gen 17:11](#)). The covenant was already in place ([Gen 12:1-3](#); [15:1-21](#); [17:1-8](#)) even before Abraham was circumcised ([Gen 17:9-14](#)). This shows that the covenant was based on faith, not

circumcision. So Abraham is the spiritual father of all people, whether circumcised (Jews) or uncircumcised (Gentiles), who have the same kind of faith Abraham had—that is, faith in God's promises ([Rom 4:13-25](#)).

Romans 4:13

the whole earth: God told Abraham that he would be the father of many nations ([4:17](#); [Gen 12:2](#); [13:16](#); [15:5](#); [17:4-6](#), [16-20](#); [22:17](#)) and that he would be the means of blessing to all people ([Gen 12:3](#); [18:18](#); [22:18](#); cp. [Isa 55:3-5](#)).

Romans 4:14

then faith is not necessary (literally *faith is emptied*): If works of obedience can be substituted for faith, then "faith is emptied" of its importance. Believing in God means acknowledging our unworthiness and depending entirely on God's mercy.

Romans 4:15

The only way to avoid breaking the law is to have no law to break! (literally *where there is no law, neither is there transgression*): Paul always uses the word "transgression" to denote disobedience of a clear commandment of God (see also [2:23](#); [5:14](#); [Gal 3:19](#); [1 Tim 2:14](#)). Transgression only exists where the law exists, which is why the law always brings punishment. The law that God gave to the Israelites specified requirements in great detail, which made the people more accountable for sin than before. So when they inevitably disobeyed the law, God brought more severe punishment upon them.

Romans 4:16

whether or not we live according to the law of Moses (literally *not only those who are of the law*): The Jews were *of the law* in that their covenant with God included the law of Moses and they were to live according to it.

Romans 4:24

raised . . . from the dead: Abraham experienced the life-giving power of God in the birth of his son Isaac. Christians witness it in the resurrection of Jesus. Throughout history, salvation has been available only through faith in God, who makes and keeps his promises.

Romans 5:1

we have peace: In many manuscripts, the underlying Greek verb is indicative, as translated here. A number of other manuscripts use the subjunctive instead (*let us have peace*). • Peace with God does not refer to a mere feeling of peacefulness but to a real situation of peace. It is the end of hostilities between God and sinful human beings when they believe in Jesus Christ and the state of blessing and salvation that God promised his people in the end (see [Isa 9:6–7](#); [52:7](#); [Ezek 34:25](#); [Nah 1:15](#)).

Romans 5:1–8.39

Paul now turns from the Good News about how people enter a relationship with God to the security of that relationship. Christians have a strong and unassailable promise because of God's work in Christ, God's love for them, and the power of the Holy Spirit. This theme frames the teaching of these chapters ([5:1–11](#); [8:18–39](#)) as Paul grounds that promise in the transfer of believers from the realm of Adam to the realm of Christ ([5:12–21](#)). No power—whether sin (ch [6](#)), the law (ch [7](#)), or death ([8:1–13](#))—"will ever be able to separate us from the love of God" ([8:39](#)).

Romans 5:2

undeserved privilege (or *grace*): So basic is God's grace (Greek *charis*) that Paul can use the word to sum up our present situation as believers. • Where we now stand indicates that God's grace is needed throughout the Christian life, not just at the beginning. • Sharing God's glory describes the content of Christian hope, which Paul introduces here and expounds more fully in [8:18–30](#). Behind Paul's use of the word *glory* (Greek *doxa*) is the Hebrew word *kabod*, which depicts God's majesty and overwhelming presence. The prophets predict

a day when God's glory will return to dwell in the midst of his people (see, e.g., [Isa 60:1–2](#)).

Romans 5:3–4

See also [Jas 1:2–4](#); [1 Pet 1:6–7](#). The similarities in these passages indicate early Christian teaching common to all three of these writers.

Romans 5:5

this hope will not lead to disappointment (literally *will not put to shame*): In the Old Testament, shame sometimes refers to a negative verdict from God's judgment (e.g., [Isa 28:16](#), quoted in [Rom 9:33](#)). • he has given us the Holy Spirit to fill our hearts with his love: See [Jer 31:33–34](#); [Acts 2:17–21](#).

Romans 5:6

At just the right time might mean that God sent Christ at the time appointed in history, or that our condition as utterly helpless was the right time for God to demonstrate his love by sending his Son on our behalf.

Romans 5:9

The blood of Christ refers to Jesus' sacrificial death ([3:25](#)). In the Scriptures, *blood* is shorthand for a violent death ([Lev 17:11](#)), especially when that death atones for sins. • he will certainly save us from God's condemnation: Paul frequently speaks of salvation as the final deliverance of believers from God's wrath and the tribulations of this life (see [Rom 13:11](#)).

Romans 5:10

saved through the life of his Son: Believers already share in the new life that Christ provided through his resurrection ([6:11](#)). Through this vital connection with Christ, believers will also be spared from God's wrath in the last day (see also [Col 3:4](#)).

Romans 5:12

Adam is both the name of the original man, Adam, and a Hebrew word that means “human.” Paul emphasizes the solidarity of Adam with the human race. • sin entered the world: The significance that Paul ascribes to this act, and the parallel that he draws between Adam’s sin and Christ’s act of obedience on the cross, makes clear that Paul views Adam and his sin in the Garden of Eden as historical fact. • everyone sinned: Death is universal because sin is universal. It is not clear when or how everyone sinned, but Paul later attributes the condemnation of all people to the sin of Adam, their representative (5:18). • Jewish tradition is divided on the relationship between Adam’s sin and the sin and death of human beings generally. Some texts emphasize a solidarity between Adam and all other people, as in “when Adam sinned a death was decreed against those who were to be born” (2 *Baruch* 23:4). Other texts insist that people die because of their own sin: “Adam is, therefore, not the cause, except only for himself, but each of us had become our own Adam” (2 *Baruch* 54:19).

Romans 5:13–14

Paul continues his explanation of “everyone sinned” (5:12) by stating that people who died between the times of Adam and Moses were not subject to specific commandments from God. Therefore, their condemnation was not only because of their own sin. It was because of their union with Adam, who sinned by violating an explicit commandment of God.

Romans 5:15

Paul uses the word many in contrast with one. *Many* does not always mean *all*, but it can include all people if the context suggests it. Clearly, the many who suffer death because of Adam includes everyone (see 5:12), but Paul makes it clear elsewhere that the many who receive the gift of forgiveness through Jesus Christ, sadly, does not include everyone (see 11:1–5).

Romans 5:17

Both Adam and Jesus Christ committed a single act whose influence extends to all the people that they

represent. Adam represents all people. People must receive the gift of righteousness to be represented by Christ.

Romans 5:18

Christ’s one act of righteousness refers to his death on the cross, a righteous act because Christ chose to die in obedience to the Father’s will (see [John 10:18](#)). • new life for everyone: Paul is not teaching that all people will experience the new life that Christ won through his death on the cross. New life is available to everyone through Christ, but not everyone receives it.

Romans 5:20

Many Jews believed that the giving of the law to Israel reversed or mitigated the negative effects of Adam’s sin, but Paul says that God’s law magnified and illuminated their sins.

Romans 6:1

Well then: Because Paul has just proclaimed that God multiplies grace where sin increases (5:20), he knows that people will wonder whether this means that sin does not matter in the Christian life.

Romans 6:2

we have died to sin: As Paul makes clear in 6:3–10, our new relationship to sin is possible because of our vital connection with the death of Jesus. Just as dying means entrance into an entirely new state of being, our relationship with sin is now different because of Christ’s death. To be “dead to sin” does not mean to be entirely insensitive to sin and temptation—believers are still involved in a battle with sin (6:12–14). However, Christians no longer have to live as helpless slaves to sin; they can choose not to sin (6:6, 14, 16–22).

Romans 6:3

Baptism is the rite of initiation into the Christian faith (see [Acts 2:38, 41](#)). It sometimes symbolizes the entire conversion experience, so Paul refers to baptism as the means through which believers are

joined to Christ in his death and resurrection (see also [Rom 6:4](#)). However, baptism has no value apart from faith.

Romans 6:4

we died and were buried with Christ: The believer's power over sin and the ability to lead a new life stem from identification with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection (see [6:5](#), [8](#)). From God's perspective, Jesus' death to sin (see [6:10](#)) is ours as well. His rising to new life means that we also begin to lead a new life, and in the future our bodies will also be raised.

Romans 6:6

our old sinful selves: Our "old selves" are not a nature that we possess or just one part of who we are; it reflects who we were in Adam. All human beings were born "in Adam." As heirs of the sin and death that he introduced into the world ([5:12](#)), we were slaves to the power of sin. But as people who are now in Christ, we have gone through crucifixion with him (see also [Gal 2:20](#)). When he died on the cross, we also died to the dominating power of sin that ruled in our former selves.

Romans 6:8

We will also live with him refers to bodily resurrection with Christ (see [6:5](#)). While believers are already raised with Christ spiritually ([Eph 2:5-6](#); [Col 2:13](#)), we will also be raised with him bodily at the time of his coming in glory ([2 Cor 4:14](#); [Phil 3:21](#); [1 Thes 4:17](#); [2 Tim 2:11](#)).

Romans 6:10

he died once to break the power of sin: Because we died with Jesus ([6:4-5](#)), we have also died to sin ([6:2](#)). Jesus was never under sin's power in the way that we are, because he had no sin nature from Adam and he never succumbed to temptation ([2 Cor 5:21](#); [Heb 4:15](#)). However, when he became human, he entered the arena where sin holds sway, and he was truly vulnerable to sin.

Romans 6:14

you no longer live under the requirements of the law: With the Messiah's coming, the era governed by the law of Moses came to an end (see [Gal 3:19-25](#)). • you live under the freedom of God's grace: God's dealings with his people have always been characterized by grace, but grace dominates the new era in which Christians live in Christ. Cp. [John 1:17](#).

Romans 6:15

set us free from the law: The law of Moses was the governing power of the old covenant era. Believers now live under the governing power of Christ himself.

Romans 6:16

righteous living (Greek *dikaiousunē*, "righteousness"): In the first part of Romans, Paul uses this Greek word in a judicial sense, referring (1) to the activity of God to set people in a right relationship with himself or (2) to the righteous standing that believers enjoy as a result of Christ's work (see, e.g., [1:17](#); [3:21-22](#); [4:3](#), [5](#)). Here, Paul uses the same word as it is often used in the Old Testament, meaning the right behavior that God demands from his people.

Romans 6:19

Paul uses the Greek word *sarx* (human nature, or *flesh*) to refer to the frailty and proneness to sin that characterizes humans. Paul uses the illustration of slavery to show the relationship of the human nature to sin.

Romans 6:20

free from the obligation to do right (literally *free from righteousness*): Paul means either that unbelievers feel no obligation to obey God or that they are unable to do so. But the freedom that they boast of actually makes them slaves to sin.

Romans 6:21

eternal doom (literally *death*): Throughout [chs 5-8](#), Paul uses *death* to describe the eternal consequences of sin ([5:12, 14, 15, 17, 21; 6:16, 23; 7:5, 9-10, 13, 24; 8:2, 6, 13](#)). The language goes back to God's warning to Adam and Eve ([Gen 2:17](#)). This death is not primarily physical death; it denotes separation from the fellowship of God that, if not reversed through faith in Christ, will last forever.

Romans 7:1

Both Jewish Christians and many of the Gentile Christians were familiar with the law. Jews were taught the law of Moses from birth. Many of the Gentiles in the church at Rome had been God-fearers, Gentiles who were interested in Judaism and attended the synagogue regularly. • the law applies only while a person is living: Paul may be paraphrasing a rabbinic saying: "If a person is dead, he is free from the Torah and the fulfilling of the commandments" (*Babylonian Shabbat* 30a; *baraita Shabbat* 151).

Romans 7:2-3

These verses are not an allegory, in which every element of the story has a theological counterpart. Paul simply cites an illustration to make two basic points: Death can release a person from obligation to the law, and freedom from one relationship can allow a person to establish a new one. Paul applies the illustration in [7:4](#).

Romans 7:4

Christians have died to the power of the law (literally *died to the law*) and so are no longer bound to it. Paul often refers to the law of Moses as representing the old regime of sin and death, but through union with Christ in his death, believers are set free.

Romans 7:5

old nature (literally *flesh*): Although "flesh" can refer to the human body in a neutral sense (see [8:3](#), which speaks of Christ coming "in the flesh"), Paul

more often uses the word negatively, to denote human existence apart from God. To be "in the flesh" is to be dominated by sin and its hostility to God. • the law aroused these evil desires: The law of God is a good thing in itself (see [7:12](#)), but it arouses sinful tendencies by provoking the rebellion that is in people's hearts. When we are in rebellion against God, his commands spark in us a desire to do the exact opposite of what he commands.

Romans 7:6

the letter of the law (literally *the letter*): Paul uses the word *letter* to refer to the law, which was engraved on tablets of stone and consisted of individual *letters* (see [2:29; 2 Cor 3:5-7](#)).

Romans 7:7-25

Well then (see study note on 6:1): Paul has just said some rather negative things about the law, and he now explains how God's law is good in order to guard against any notion that it is evil in itself.

Romans 7:8

sin used this command (literally *sin took an opportunity through this command*): The word *opportunity* is a military term for a position seized in enemy territory that becomes a base of operations (see [7:11](#)). By expressing God's demands, the commandments stimulate rebellion in sinful human beings. The commandments of God become an occasion for sin to accomplish its deadly purposes. • sin would not have that power: The law, by clearly expressing God's will, makes people more accountable than they would be without it. The law of Moses did not solve Israel's sin problem but exposed and exacerbated it. This is always the effect that God's law, by itself, has on sinful human beings.

Romans 7:9

At one time I lived without understanding the law: Paul might be referring to his early childhood, before he came to understand the full demands of the law. • But when I learned the command: Paul's experience with the law as he grew to maturity

exemplifies every person's experience with it. With the law, we have greater accountability to God, which brings the power of sin to life, and the result is greater judgment ([7:10](#); see [4:15](#); [5:14](#), [20](#)).

Romans 7:10

which were supposed to bring life: The Old Testament promised a blessed and secure life to those who obeyed the law (e.g., [Lev 18:5](#), quoted in [Rom 10:5](#)). However, human beings inherit from Adam a strong tendency to sin. Therefore, when God's commands come to us, we do not naturally obey them, but resist and disobey them. Instead of bringing life, the law only confirms and exposes our lost and helpless condition. We need a change of heart that the law cannot provide.

Romans 7:11

Sin . . . deceived me: The language is reminiscent of [Gen 3:13](#)—Paul might be thinking of the Fall.

Romans 7:17

I am not the one doing wrong: Paul is not evading responsibility for his sin (see also [7:20](#)). Rather, he is saying that because he genuinely wants to do what the law commands, some other factor must be causing him to do just the opposite. That factor is sin living in me. Paul experiences a divide between his will and his actions.

Romans 7:18

my sinful nature: See study note on 6:19. This phrase could refer to Paul's former state as an unredeemed person or to a part of Paul that remains tied to the world and resists the will of God.

Romans 7:21

principle of life (literally *law*): Paul is referring to a regular occurrence, such as when we speak of the "law of gravity." The struggle between wanting to do what is right and instead doing what is wrong reveals a regular pattern operating in the human sphere.

Romans 7:22

with all my heart (literally *in my inner person*): The Greeks used this phrase to denote the spiritual or immortal side of human beings (cp. [2 Cor 4:16](#); [Eph 3:16](#)).

Romans 7:23

another power. . . . This power (literally *another law*. . . . *This law*): Paul plays on the word *law* in these verses. Opposed to God's law ([7:22](#)) is another law, a ruling *power* that prevents Paul from submitting to God's law even though he fully agrees with it.

Romans 7:24

this life that is dominated by sin and death (literally *this body of death*): Sin is so invasive that it affects the whole person, particularly our interactions in the physical world.

Romans 8:1

So now there is no condemnation: Paul concludes from the argument of chs [5–7](#) that neither sin (ch [6](#)) nor the law (ch [7](#)) can keep believers from having eternal life (ch [5](#)). Paul can triumphantly proclaim that those who belong to Christ Jesus need not fear that they will be condemned for their sins.

Romans 8:2

the power (literally *the law*) of the life-giving Spirit: This reference to *power* or *law* could refer to the law of Moses, which the Spirit can use to produce life. But because Paul does not portray the law as a life-giving entity, "law" here, as in [7:23](#), probably means *principle* or *power*. The Holy Spirit is a power that frees the believer from the power of sin that leads to death.

Romans 8:3

our sinful nature: See study note on 6:19. • in a body like the bodies we sinners have: Jesus identified with sinful people so that he could be their representative and redeem them. Paul also implies that Jesus' incarnate nature was not exactly like ours; born of a virgin through the power of the Holy Spirit, Jesus did not inherit a sinful nature from Adam. • a sacrifice for our sins: In the Greek Old Testament, this phrase frequently describes a sin offering, and three of the eight New Testament occurrences also have this meaning ([Heb 10:6, 8; 13:11](#)). Christ was the sin offering that brought forgiveness and turned away God's wrath. God condemned sin in Christ, our substitute, so that we could escape condemnation.

Romans 8:4

just requirement of the law . . . fully satisfied for (Greek en, "in") us: The Greek preposition en might indicate that the law is fulfilled *in* us because of our connection with Jesus Christ, who perfectly fulfilled the law for us. It could also mean that by setting us free from sin's power, Jesus Christ enables us to please God and fulfill the true intention of the law. • As in the Old Testament (see [Gen 6:3, 12; Ps 78:39; Isa 40:6](#)), sinful nature refers to human weakness and bondage to sin (also in [Rom 8:5-9, 12-13](#)). Paul uses the phrase to describe the conflict between the ingrained human tendency to sin and the Holy Spirit.

Romans 8:5

think about sinful things: This phrase describes the general nature of a person's will, not just the mental process of thought (see also [12:3; 15:5; Phil 2:2, 5](#)).

Romans 8:6

Peace here does not refer merely to peace of mind; instead, as opposed to death, it implies an objective state of peace with God (see study note on 5:1).

Romans 8:9

You are controlled by the Spirit: In contrast to unbelievers, who continue to live under the domination of Adam's sinful nature, believers are directed in their lives by the Holy Spirit. The Spirit does not take away human initiative or make it impossible for believers to sin. However, as the most powerful force in believers' lives, the Spirit makes it possible for them to resist the continuing power of sin.

Romans 8:10

the Spirit gives you life: The Spirit opposes sin (which leads to physical death) and brings resurrection from the dead.

Romans 8:11

by this same Spirit: The Holy Spirit is the agent of the resurrection of our bodies. Some manuscripts read "*because of the same Spirit*," which would mean that the Spirit is the guarantee that our bodies will be raised (cp. [Eph 1:14](#)).

Romans 8:13

you will die: Death is the consequence of sin. Those who consistently yield to sin will suffer spiritual death (eternal condemnation). The presence of the Holy Spirit in the lives of believers makes it possible for them to turn away from sin. The result is eternal life (you will live).

Romans 8:14

children of God: In the Old Testament, this phrase referred to Israel, the people God called to be his own (see especially [Exod 4:22; Jer 3:19; 31:9; Hos 11:1](#)). Paul uses it to remind believers that they enjoy an intimate relationship with God and that they will inherit many of the promises and blessings given to Israel. Christians are no longer minors or slaves, but mature children with full rights (see [Gal 4:1-7](#)).

Romans 8:15

you received God's Spirit when he adopted you as his own children: According to Greco-Roman customs of adoption, a man had the right to adopt a son and to confer on that child all the legal rights and privileges that would be given to a natural child. This practice extended even to the imperial family. The Roman emperor Julius Caesar adopted Octavian as his heir; Octavian, using the name Augustus, later ruled the Roman Empire. Paul's concept of adoption is also rooted in the Old Testament and Judaism ([Exod 4:22](#); [Deut 1:31](#); [Hos 11:1](#); see also [Rom 9:4](#); [Gal 4:5](#); [Eph 1:5](#)). • Abba: This word was used in an intimate family context ("Daddy"). Jesus used this word to address God ([Mark 14:36](#)); all those who become children of God through Jesus have the privilege of addressing God in the same way.

Romans 8:17

Jesus is heir to all of God's promises ([Mark 12:1–12](#); [Gal 3:18–19](#); [Heb 1:2](#)), and as those who belong to Jesus, we share with him in that glorious inheritance. However, just as it was for Jesus, our path to glory is also marked by suffering. We experience the difficulties that come from striving to live righteously in a world dominated by sin ([2 Cor 1:5](#); [Phil 1:29](#); [3:10](#)).

Romans 8:19–21

All creation includes animals, plants, and the earth itself. Paul follows Old Testament precedent (see especially [Ps 65:12–13](#); [Isa 24:4](#); [Jer 4:28](#); [12:4](#)) by personifying the created world. • waiting eagerly . . . looks forward: Just as the entire world was harmed by Adam's fall into sin, it will share in the blessings that God has promised his people (e.g., [Isa 4:2](#), [Rev 21:1–2](#)).

Romans 8:22

The pains of childbirth is a metaphor for the longing of creation (see also [Matt 24:8](#); [Mark 13:8](#); [John 16:20–22](#)).

Romans 8:23

we believers also groan: "Groaning" expresses a frustrated longing for God's deliverance from the difficulties and oppression of this life (see [Exod 3:7](#); [Lam 1:22](#); [Ezek 24:17](#); [2 Cor 5:2](#)). • we have the Holy Spirit within us as a foretaste of future glory (literally *we have the first harvest of the Spirit*): In the Old Testament, the phrase *first harvest* or *firstfruits* often describes the offering of the first and best part of a harvest to God (see [Exod 23:19](#); [Lev 2:12](#); [23:10](#); cp. [1 Cor 15:20](#), [23](#)). The Holy Spirit is God's pledge that he will see his work in us through to its conclusion (see [Eph 1:14](#)). • Although we have already been adopted by God as his children, the full rights of that adoption—our inheritance (see [Rom 8:17](#))—are not yet ours. In this life, Christians live in tension between the "already" of redemption and the "not yet" of the glory to be revealed.

Romans 8:26

groanings that cannot be expressed in words: This might refer to speech that does not take the form of human language, such as when believers, uncertain of what to pray, utter meaningless sounds in prayer. The groanings in question are the Spirit's, not ours. When we do not know how to pray, the Spirit is interceding for us before God.

Romans 8:30

gave them his glory: Elsewhere in this passage, the *glory* Christians will experience is consistently in the future ([8:18](#), [21](#), [23](#)). The past tense here refers to God's past decision to glorify us in the future. We have not yet entered into our inheritance, but the Father has irrevocably determined to give us his glory.

Romans 8:31

such wonderful things: Paul is referring to everything he has taught in chs [5–8](#) about the blessings and sense of assurance that believers receive from their relationship with God.

Romans 8:32

did not spare even his own Son: Behind this language is the story about Abraham's willingness to offer his son Isaac ([Gen 22:12](#), [16](#)). Isaac, however, was not actually sacrificed. God's not sparing his only Son went the full course: He handed him over to the shameful and painful death of crucifixion.

Romans 9:1–11:36

In this section, Paul takes up the problem raised by the unbelief of so many Jews. If God had promised salvation to Israel yet so few Jews were being saved, how could Jesus truly be the fulfillment of God's plan ([9:1–5](#))? In his response to this objection, Paul cites the Old Testament as evidence that God had always intended to save only a remnant of Israel ([9:6–29](#)), and he faults the Jews for refusing to embrace Christ ([9:30–10:21](#)). Paul then shows that God has not discarded Israel from his plan of salvation. Many Jews have already believed in Christ ([11:1–10](#)), and many more will believe in the future ([11:12–26](#)).

Romans 9:2–3

Paul does not explicitly say why he has such bitter sorrow for his Jewish brothers and sisters. Yet his willingness to become cursed on their behalf if that would save them makes clear that the failure of most Jews to respond to Jesus and be saved stimulated his agony (see also [10:1](#)).

Romans 9:3

I would be willing to be forever cursed (Greek anathema): Anathema is used in the Greek Old Testament to translate a Hebrew expression that means "set apart for God," which usually has the negative sense of something destined to be destroyed as an offering to God (see [Lev 27:28–29](#); [Josh 6:17–18](#); [7:1](#), [11–13](#); [22:20](#); [1 Sam 15:3](#); [1 Chr 2:7](#)). Paul knows that he cannot, in fact, be cut off from Christ. Paul is echoing the offer of Moses, who pled with God to kill him but to spare the people ([Exod 32:30–32](#)).

Romans 9:4

Up to this point in Romans, Paul has called the Jewish people *Jews*. His shift to people of Israel, here and throughout most of chs [9–11](#), is significant. *Jew* connotes national identity, but *Israel* emphasizes the covenant relationship of the people with God. • chosen to be God's adopted children: The Old Testament called Israel God's *son* or *child* to emphasize that God had selected Israel to be his own people (e.g., [Exod 4:22](#); [Jer 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [Hos 11:1](#)). Israel's adopted status meant that they received God's blessing and promises, not that they were necessarily saved. • covenants: The Old Testament includes several covenants between God and the people of Israel: one with Abraham ([Gen 17](#)), one with the nation through Moses at Mount Sinai ([Exod 19–24](#)), and one with David ([2 Sam 7:8–16](#); [23:5](#)).

Romans 9:5

Christ came from the people of Israel, and God first made his promises of salvation to them.

Romans 9:6

are truly members of God's people (literally *are Israel*): "Israel" can refer to the people of Israel in a biological sense, i.e., everyone descended from Jacob. But in the latter part of the Old Testament and in Judaism, the idea of a "righteous remnant" within Israel developed (see [Isa 11:10–16](#)). On at least one occasion in the New Testament, Israel refers to everyone, Jew and Gentile, who belongs to God in a spiritual sense ([Gal 6:16](#)). Paul is stating that there is now an "Israel within Israel," a community consisting of both Jews and Gentiles who truly believe (cp. [Rom 11:16–17](#); [Gal 6:16](#)).

Romans 9:7

This quotation is from [Gen 21:12](#), which God spoke to Abraham when he was reluctant to follow Sarah's advice to banish his son Ishmael, who was born to the slave woman Hagar. God assured Abraham that Sarah's child, Isaac, was the son through whom God's promises would be fulfilled.

Romans 9:10–11

she gave birth to twins: No human circumstances differentiated Isaac's sons, Jacob and Esau. Not only were they born to the same mother, but they were also conceived at the same time. Instead, Paul argues, the difference between them was of God's choosing.

Romans 9:12

"Your older son will serve your younger son": God spoke these words to Rebekah before the twins were born ([Gen 25:23](#)). As the older of the twins, Esau was Isaac's natural heir. But Esau sold his birthright to Jacob and ceded his position to his brother in fulfillment of God's promise.

Romans 9:13

"I loved Jacob, but I rejected (literally *hated*) Esau": Paul quotes [Mal 1:2–3](#), where Jacob, whose other name is Israel ([Gen 32:28](#)), stands for the nation of Israel, and Esau stands for Edom. Here, Paul is referring to them as individuals. Just as love can sometimes express a choice, so hate can express rejection. The story of Jacob and Esau illustrates how the sovereign God chooses his own people.

Romans 9:14–16

God's choice is not unfair because he owes nothing to his sinful creatures (see study note on 4:4–5).

Romans 9:15

This quotation from [Exod 33:19](#) focuses on God's nature: God is free from obligation or constraint in bestowing mercy on people.

Romans 9:17

God told Pharaoh: At God's direction, Moses had asked Pharaoh to let the people of Israel leave Egypt for their own land ([Exod 9:16](#)). When Pharaoh stubbornly refused, God displayed miracle after miracle to convince Israel, Pharaoh, and the Egyptians of God's power and authority (see [Exod 6:7](#); [7:5](#); [9:14–16](#); [14:31](#)).

Romans 9:18

he chooses to harden the hearts of others so they refuse to listen: Pharaoh refused to let Israel go because his heart was hardened. God hardened Pharaoh's heart ([Exod 9:12](#)), and Pharaoh hardened his own heart ([Exod 8:15](#)).

Romans 9:20–21

See [Isa 29:16](#); [45:9–10](#).

Romans 9:24–26

God was free to select people from the Jews who would have a true spiritual relationship with him; similarly, he was also free to choose some from the Gentiles to be saved as well. Paul uses the prophecy of Hosea to reinforce his point. Hosea predicted that God would renew his mercy to the ten northern tribes that had rebelled against God and were under his judgment. Paul saw a principle that applies to Gentiles as well. • Those who were not my people: See study note on 10:19.

Romans 9:27–28

only a remnant will be saved: So many Israelites had turned from God that the Old Testament prophets spoke of a true spiritual Israel within the larger nation of Israel (see [Isa 11:10–16](#)). The remnant would receive salvation, while the rest of the Israelites would suffer condemnation.

Romans 9:29

The destruction of the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 19](#)) is a poignant illustration of the reality and severity of God's judgment.

Romans 9:31

who tried so hard to get right with God by keeping the law (literally *who pursued the law of righteousness*): *Law of righteousness* is an idiom that means "righteousness through the law."

Romans 9:32-33

The great rock in their path is Christ. People either build on him by putting their faith in him, or they stumble over his message that faith, and not human works, is the key to getting right with God.

Romans 9:33

This quotation is from [Isa 8:14](#); [28:16](#). These two texts, along with [Ps 118:22](#), are also quoted together in [1 Pet 2:6-8](#). The early church likely had a collection of messianic “stone” quotations from the Old Testament that they used to illuminate the significance of Christ (see also [Matt 21:42](#)).

Romans 10:2

Zeal denotes a passionate and commendable commitment to God and his purposes (see [Num 25:6-13](#)). But in Paul’s day Jewish zeal was misdirected because it failed to understand that Jesus Christ is the pinnacle of God’s plan. (For Paul’s own misdirected zeal before his conversion to Christ, see [Acts 9:1-2](#); [Gal 1:13-14](#).)

Romans 10:3

God’s way of making people right with himself: See [1:17](#); [3:21-26](#). Paul uses this phrase to explain Israel’s failure in terms basic to the gospel. God manifested his righteousness through the ministry of Christ, but most Jews did not understand it, partly because they were so focused on the law as a way of securing their own righteousness.

Romans 10:4

The function of the law was to point forward and prepare the way for the Messiah; Jesus’ coming does not destroy the law but fulfills all of its requirements, so that the primary requirement for God’s people is to believe in him (see [3:31](#); [Matt 5:17-18](#)).

Romans 10:5

requires obedience to all of its commands: See [Lev 18:5](#), where these words encouraged the Israelites to obey the law in order to enjoy long life and prosperity in the land that God was giving them (see also [Lev 26:3-13](#); [Deut 28:1-14](#)). Paul sees the implication that if people want to be right with God through the law, they can only do so by obeying all of it.

Romans 10:6-8

Here Paul quotes three phrases from [Deut 30:12-14](#) dealing with the law, and he applies them to the Good News about Christ. We do not need to go up to heaven to find Christ (and thus to be made right with God), because God has already brought him down to earth as a man. Nor do we need to go down to the place of the dead to find Christ, because God has already raised him from the dead. To find Christ, we must simply believe in the message that is close at hand.

Romans 10:13

Paul quotes [Joel 2:32](#), where the Lord in Hebrew is *Yahweh*, the personal name of God (see [Exod 3:15](#)). However, as [Rom 10:12](#) makes clear, *the Lord* in Romans is Jesus Christ. This verse shows that Christians from the time of the apostles have associated Jesus with God.

Romans 10:14

It is natural to presume that the pronoun they refers to “all who call on him” from [10:12](#) or “everyone” from [10:13](#). While this verse probably does refer to all people, it also continues the accusation against Israel from [10:2-3](#) (see [10:18](#)). Paul argues that Israel was in a position to know what God was doing through Jesus Christ, so they were culpable for their failure to understand or accept it. Israel was guilty both of failing to understand God’s plan in light of Christ ([10:3-4](#)) and of focusing so much attention on the law that they missed Christ when he arrived ([9:30-32](#)).

Romans 10:18

Yes, they have: Paul quotes [Ps 19:4](#) to show that the message of Good News was universally available through creation. And by the time Paul wrote Romans, early Christian missionaries had spread the Good News through most of the Roman Empire. Most Jews would have had ample opportunity to hear the message.

Romans 10:19

rouse your jealousy . . . provoke your anger: This quotation from [Deut 32:21](#) concerns God's punishment of Israel for their idolatry. In Paul's day, Israel remained guilty of idolatry because it put the law in place of God himself. God's punishment involved using the Gentiles, people who are not even a nation, to make Israel jealous and angry ([Rom 11:12-32](#) elaborates on this theme).

Romans 10:20

This quotation is from [Isa 65:1](#). In Isaiah, the words people who were not looking for me refer to the people of Israel. As in [Rom 9:25-26](#), Paul applies them to the Gentiles to show that God has opened the way for them to be a part of the people of God.

Romans 11:2

chose from the very beginning: Before the people of Israel could do anything to earn their status, God selected them to be his people based on his grace alone. • Elijah the prophet: In [1 Kgs 19:1-18](#), the apostate King Ahab had slaughtered many of the Lord's prophets, and Ahab's wife Jezebel threatened Elijah with the same fate. Elijah fled to the wilderness, where he bemoaned his fate. God responded with the assurance that many faithful people remained. Paul found the present situation to be somewhat parallel. While many Jews did not believe, and some were even hostile, God was (and is) still working to preserve a believing remnant.

Romans 11:5

a few of the people of Israel (literally *a remnant*): Paul returns to the Old Testament concept of the

remnant that he used in [9:27-29](#). This solid core of godly Israelites represents God's pledge of his continuing faithfulness to his promises and to his people.

Romans 11:7-8

the hearts of the rest were hardened: This is God's own work; God has put them into a deep sleep and shut their eyes. See [Acts 13:46-48](#); [18:6](#).

Romans 11:11

so God made salvation available to the Gentiles: The offer of salvation to the Gentiles is the purpose, not just the result, of Israel's disobedience. Paul emphasizes that God had the salvation of Gentiles in view all along, and, ultimately, the salvation of many Jews as well. • he wanted his own people to become jealous: The theme of jealousy comes from [Deut 32:21](#), which Paul quoted in [Rom 10:19](#). The sight of Gentiles enjoying the blessings of salvation that God had promised to Israel would spur Jews to desire salvation so they could participate in those blessings as well.

Romans 11:13-14

you Gentiles: Paul addresses the Gentile Christians in Rome with the practical goal of rebuking them for thinking too highly of themselves ([11:20](#)), especially in relation to their Jewish brothers and sisters. He shows that their enjoyment of salvation depends entirely on God's kindness ([11:22](#)) and that God's final goal is to stimulate repentance among the Jews ([11:23](#)). • I stress this: Paul devoted himself to the conversion of Gentiles because he knew that their salvation would ultimately lead to salvation for Jews as well.

Romans 11:15

The context emphasizes God's role in hardening many Jews ([11:7-10](#)), so the phrase their rejection likely means God's rejection of the unbelieving Jews. • Their acceptance then refers to God's acceptance of Jews into his Kingdom (see also [14:3](#) and [15:7](#)). • While the phrase life for those who were dead could refer to the new spiritual life that comes to the Jews as a result of their conversion to

Christ (see [6:13](#)), the language more naturally suggests the physical resurrection from the dead that occurs when Christ returns in glory (see, e.g., [1 Thes 4:13–18](#)).

Romans 11:16

the entire batch of dough is holy because the portion given as an offering is holy: This imagery comes from [Num 15:17–21](#), where God commanded the Israelites to take part of their first batch of dough and set it aside as a gift. God's promises to and blessings on Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were like a down payment, guaranteeing the completion of God's work among his people.

Romans 11:17–24

In Paul's extended metaphor, God's special olive tree refers to the people of God. The image is a natural one, because the olive tree is the most widely cultivated fruit tree in the Mediterranean basin, and it was already used as a symbol of Israel in the Old Testament ([Jer 11:16](#); [Hos 14:5–6](#)). Paul refers to the Gentile Christians as branches from a wild olive tree because they were not originally included among the people of God.

Romans 11:18

You are just a branch, not the root: By the time Paul wrote to the church in Rome, it was composed mainly of Gentiles, a common situation in the early Christian communities. This dominant role led many Gentile Christians to brag about their status, while treating Jews and their religious heritage with disdain. Paul reminds the Gentile believers that they enjoy God's blessings only because they have been included in the one people of God, who are rooted in God's promises to Israel.

Romans 11:20

fear what could happen: In Scripture, fear often means a reverential awe of God that includes the recognition that we must one day stand before him in judgment (see [2 Cor 5:11](#); [7:1](#), [11](#), [15](#); [Phil 2:12](#); [Col 3:22](#)).

Romans 11:22

if you stop trusting, you also will be cut off: Scripture consistently emphasizes that only believers who persevere to the end will be saved. However, Paul's warning leads to debate over the theological implications of his statement. Some think that it implies that genuine believers can stop believing and therefore not be saved in the end. Others argue that we should not press the metaphor so far and that Paul is referring to people who appear to be believers but whose lack of real faith ultimately reveals itself.

Romans 11:24

by nature . . . contrary to nature: The usual method of enhancing the yield of olive trees involved grafting a shoot from a cultivated tree onto a wild olive tree to benefit from the wild tree's vigor. By grafting wild olive branches (Gentiles) into the cultivated olive tree (the people of God), God has done what is contrary to nature.

Romans 11:25

Paul usually uses the word *mystery* to refer to an event of the last days that has already been determined by God. Such a *mystery* already exists in heaven and is revealed to God's people in the Christian era (see [16:25](#); [1 Cor 2:1](#), [7](#); [4:1](#); [15:51](#); [Eph 1:9](#); [3:3](#), [4](#), [9](#); [6:19](#); [Col 1:26](#), [27](#); [2:2](#); [4:3](#); [1 Tim 3:9](#), [16](#)). Here, the mystery is the relationship of Jews and Gentiles in the plan of salvation, which is at the heart of this entire passage ([Rom 11:11–32](#)).

Romans 11:26–27

The phrase *all Israel* could refer to the total of all believers, both Jewish and Gentile; with this meaning, and so would describe the way that God works to bring salvation to all his people. Alternatively, *all Israel* could refer to the total of all Jews destined to believe throughout the Christian era, or to a significant number of Jews who turn to Christ in the last days. With the last meaning, *and so* would have a sequential meaning—after the full number of Gentiles comes to Christ, *then* the full number of Jews will be saved. It does not mean all Jewish people (see [2:17–29](#)) • In the Old Testament, The one who rescues is the Lord. Paul

almost surely is referring to Jesus Christ (see [1 Thes 1:10](#)). • from Jerusalem: The Hebrew text of [Isa 59:20](#) says that the redeemer will come to Jerusalem. Paul might have changed the wording to represent Jesus' first coming from among the people of Israel or to speak of the second coming when Jesus will return from the heavenly Jerusalem (see [Heb 12:22](#)).

Romans 11:32

have mercy on everyone: *Everyone* has the sense of "all kinds of people." In the context of Romans, and especially this chapter, it refers to the inclusion of Gentiles alongside Jews.

Romans 11:36

everything comes from him and exists by his power: This statement is similar to statements found among Greek Stoic philosophers in their descriptions of God. Paul regularly draws on literature from the Greco-Roman world to present and clarify the truth about God and his purposes (cp. [Acts 17:24–29](#)).

Romans 12:1

Your bodies refers to the whole person in contact with the world, not just the physical body. • because of all he has done for you: As described in chs [1–11](#). • This is truly the way to worship him (or *This is your spiritual worship*; or *This is your reasonable service*): This phrase has at least three possible meanings: (1) Our sacrifice is *reasonable* in light of all God's mercies; (2) our sacrifice is *spiritual*, not the offering of an animal but of ourselves in spiritual service; or (3) our sacrifice is *intelligent*, offered with complete awareness of God's goodness to us.

Romans 12:1–15:13

This section of Romans sets out the moral and ethical demands of the Good News. God's gift of salvation in Christ requires a response. God is not satisfied simply with forgiving our sin; he wants to transform our lives. Most of what Paul teaches concerning the moral duties of believers is paralleled in other letters. However, it also seems

clear that he has chosen issues pertinent to the situation in Rome—most notably, the dispute between people who are weak in faith and people who are strong in faith ([14:1–15:13](#)).

Romans 12:2

this world (literally *this age*): The division of history into two ages was typical of the Jewish worldview. Early Christians adapted this point of view, identifying the coming of Christ as the time when the new age of salvation began. Unexpectedly, however, the new age did not bring an end to the old age. The old way of thinking and living continues, and it is a source of temptation even to Christians who seek to conform their lives to the values of the new age.

Romans 12:3

by the faith God has given us: Or *by the faith God has given you*; or *by the standard of our God-given faith*. Whether Paul is referring to the amount of faith each of us has been given or to the Christian faith that we all hold in common, we need to assess ourselves accurately by this measure and not be vain about the abilities God has given us.

Romans 12:4–5

so it is with Christ's body: The parallel between the human body and the church—the body of Christ—is also found in [1 Cor 12](#). This metaphor provides an effective picture of unity and diversity in the church (cp. Livy, *History* 2.32; Epictetus, *Discourses* 2.10.4–5).

Romans 12:6

The ability to prophesy was one of the most important of the New Testament gifts (see also [1 Cor 12:28](#); [Eph 4:11](#)). Although prophets are mentioned in several passages in Acts as predicting the future (see [Acts 11:28](#); [21:10–12](#)), the prophet's most fundamental responsibility is to communicate God's message to the community of believers ([1 Cor 12:3](#), [24–25](#), [29–30](#); see also [1 Cor 14:1–40](#)). • as much faith as God has given you (literally *in proportion to the faith*): *Proportion* (Greek *analogia*) is a word drawn from

mathematics and logic, where it refers to the correct proportions in a relationship among things, quantities, or ideas. Paul uses the phrase to remind prophets to make sure that their utterances are in right proportion to faith, whether the amount of individual faith the prophet has been given, or the Christian faith in general (see study note on Rom 12:3). This passage has given theology the phrase *the analogy of faith*, which refers to the importance of bringing the interpretation of any particular passage into line with the teaching of all of Scripture.

Romans 12:7

teacher: The gift of teaching comes third in the list of gifts in [1 Cor 12:28](#) and fifth in [Eph 4:11](#). While prophets communicate to the community a message received directly from God, teachers address the church on the basis of studying the word of God.

Romans 12:8

give generously: See also [2 Cor 8:2](#); [9:11](#), [13](#).

Romans 12:9–21

The many injunctions in these verses do not follow a neat logical arrangement. The overall topic, stated at the beginning, is sincere love. Paul shows how we are to love both those inside the church ([12:10](#), [13](#), [15–16](#)) and those outside the church ([12:14](#), [17–21](#)).

Romans 12:10

genuine affection: Literally *brotherly love*. Christians are to love each other with the mutual love and commitment that are found within a healthy family.

Romans 12:11

but work hard and serve the Lord enthusiastically: As Christians, we are to be passionate about our faith and eager to fulfill our ministry to others within the church.

Romans 12:12

The three commands in this verse are related. By rejoicing in confident hope, we can be patient in trouble. Continually praying is essential if we desire to have this attitude toward the difficulties of life (see also [8:24–27](#)).

Romans 12:13

be ready to help them: The verb Paul uses is related to the familiar Greek word *koinōnia* (“fellowship”). When needs arise among our Christian brothers and sisters, we are not just to meet their needs; we should also enter into fellowship with these fellow Christians in ways that extend beyond material gifts.

Romans 12:14

The exhortations in this verse closely resemble two sayings of Jesus ([Matt 5:44](#); [Luke 6:27–28](#)). Although Paul does not introduce the commands as a quotation, he is almost certainly alluding to these sayings of Christ. Perhaps the words were so well known that he did not need to specify the source. The teaching of [Rom 12–13](#) has many parallels with the teaching of Jesus.

Romans 12:16

All three exhortations in this verse use the Greek word *phroneō* (think). Paul addresses the need for right Christian thinking when it comes to our relationships with other Christians. • Live in harmony: Literally *Think the same things*. • Don't be too proud: Literally *Don't think arrogant things*.

Romans 12:18

Do all that you can: Paul recognizes that our efforts to live at peace with others will sometimes be frustrated by our own moral constraints or by other people's unwillingness to be reconciled to us.

Romans 12:20–21

A simple act of Christian kindness can often bring a hostile person to repentance before God and restore fellowship between people.

Romans 13:1–2

The basic command of [13:1–7](#) is to submit to governing authorities. In God's ordering of the world, we answer to those in positions of authority. Our submission to them will usually take the form of obedience. However, because God stands over all governments, our submission to governing authorities must always be in terms of our ultimate submission to God (see [Acts 4:19–20](#)). The Roman Christians might have been resisting government (see study note on Rom 13:6) based on a false understanding of the Good News, as if no longer copying "the behavior and customs of this world" ([12:2](#)) meant that they could ignore earthly institutions. • placed there by God: Scripture consistently teaches that God is actively involved in raising up and casting down human governments and leaders ([1 Sam 2:6–10](#); [12:8](#); [Prov 8:15–16](#); [Isa 41:2–4](#); [45:1–7](#); [Jer 21:7, 10](#); [27:5–6](#); [Dan 2:21, 37–38](#); [4:17](#)). God instituted governing authorities, so rebelling against them is rebelling against God, who will respond with judgment ([Rom 13:2](#)).

Romans 13:3

the authorities do not strike fear in people who are doing right: Paul presents a positive picture of the governing authorities, describing them in terms of what God has appointed them to do. He does not touch on situations where leaders punish those who do good and reward those who do evil, although he was certainly aware of such situations from Old Testament and Jewish history, from the experience of Jesus and the other apostles, and from Greco-Roman affairs. Here, Paul confines himself to discussing the appropriate response to governing authorities who live according to their calling.

Romans 13:4

- **Servant:** The New Testament often uses this Greek word (*diakonos*) to describe Christians serving God in different roles. In non-religious Greek, *diakonos* can also refer to a city official. A government and its leaders serve God by administering justice, whether they realize it or not.
- *he does not carry the sword in vain:* Here, *the sword* might be a metaphor for any punishment. Some interpreters believe it means human governments, under God's authority, have the right to use capital punishment. (Capital punishment is the practice of killing someone as a legal penalty for certain crimes.)

Romans 13:5

The two reasons for submission sum up the argument of [13:1–4](#) in reverse order: to avoid punishment relates to [13:3–4](#), while to keep a clear conscience refers to [13:1–2](#). • The word conscience (Greek *suneidēsis*) refers to the painful knowledge of wrongdoing. Christians know about their duty to submit to governing authorities, and their failure to do so would bring the pain of a guilty conscience.

Romans 13:6

Pay your taxes: Jesus referred to paying taxes in his famous pronouncement about the disciples' relationship to government ([Matt 22:21](#)). A tax revolt occurred in Rome at about the time that Paul was writing, so Paul's whole discussion of the Christian's responsibility to government might have been sparked by his knowledge that Roman Christians were participating in this tax revolt (see Tacitus, *Annals* 13).

Romans 13:8

The idea of obligation is the hinge that connects [13:1–7](#) and [13:8–10](#). Christians are to "give to

everyone what [they] owe them” (13:7), and Christians always owe love to their neighbors. • Owe nothing to anyone: Debts are not sinful but should be avoided and, if incurred, should be promptly repaid so that the believer is free to serve in love (see [Prov 22:7](#)). • love one another: Believers are called to love all those they encounter ([Rom 12:14–21](#); [Luke 10:25–37](#)), but the phrase especially emphasizes the love that each believer owes to other believers. • you will fulfill the requirements of God’s law: This teaching closely follows Jesus’ teaching in [Matt 22:34–40](#).

Romans 13:8–10

These verses discuss how believers relate to other people. If we truly love others, our actions will reflect all the commandments in the law that concern our relationships with other people.

Romans 13:11

The New Testament often speaks of salvation as the final victory over sin and death that believers will experience when Jesus returns in glory (see [5:9–10](#)).

Romans 13:12–13

the day of salvation: The word *day* reflects two sources. First, the Old Testament repeatedly predicts the *day of the Lord* when God’s plan culminates (see [Isa 13:4–13](#); [Jer 3:18](#); [30:8–9](#); [Joel 2:1–32](#); [Obad 1:15–18](#)). Second, the tradition of moral instruction in the ancient world associated light/daytime with good and darkness/nighttime with evil. The Greeks, Romans, and Jews all used this contrast. Because believers belong to the day they should be living out its values, avoiding the dark deeds that are typical of nighttime.

Romans 14:1

Being weak in faith means having scruples against doing certain things that Christian liberty would allow. In Rome, most of the weak in faith were Jewish Christians whose consciences did not give them liberty from certain requirements of Jewish law.

Romans 14:1–15.7

Paul moves to a specific issue that was causing conflict in the church at Rome. The church in Rome was embroiled in a dispute between people who were weak in faith and people who were strong (see [15:1](#)) regarding certain practices. Throughout this section, Paul instructs believers to be tolerant toward others and their practices; he is convinced that people on both sides of the issue are genuine believers, and he does not think the issues they are fighting over are essential to the faith.

Romans 14:2

The weak in faith apparently believed that they should eat only vegetables. Their conviction probably stemmed from a concern to maintain Jewish ritual purity in the midst of a pagan culture. These Jewish Christians were following the lead of Daniel and his friends, who refused to eat the rich food and wine that the king of Babylon offered them ([Dan 1:3–16](#)). Other Jewish sources reveal that pious Jews often restricted their diets in pagan cultures because they could never be sure that meat had been slaughtered according to Jewish requirements.

Romans 14:3–4

look down on . . . condemn: The “strong,” those who prided themselves on their enlightened freedom in Christ, looked with disdain on those they considered to be “weak.” The weak, in turn—certain that they were following the true route to piety—condemned the strong for their laxness. These attitudes, over different issues, are mirrored throughout the history of the Christian church. • God has accepted them: Both the weak and the strong are genuine believers, welcomed by God into his family. Therefore, they have no right to treat each other as if they do not belong ([14:4](#); see also [15:7](#)).

Romans 14:5

some think one day is more holy than another day, while others think every day is alike: The reference is probably to Jewish festival days and to the

Sabbath; cp. [Col 2:16](#). With Christ's provision of salvation, observance of the Sabbath in its original form is not required of Christians.

Romans 14:7

As the Lord's servants ([14:4](#)), Christians are to look to God for guidance and seek to honor him in all things ([14:8](#)). Because we are ultimately accountable to him, our desire should always be to please him, not to live for ourselves.

Romans 14:9

Paul refers to standard early Christian teaching on the significance of Jesus' death and resurrection (e.g., [2 Cor 5:15](#)). • of the living and of the dead (literally *of the dead and of the living*): The original word order matches the sequence of Jesus' death and resurrection, the redemptive events that make Jesus our Lord.

Romans 14:10

we will all stand before the judgment seat of God: Paul reminds the Roman Christians that it is the Lord, not other Christians, who will ultimately judge all of us (cp. [2 Cor 5:10](#)).

Romans 14:11

This quotation is from [Isa 49:18](#); [45:23](#). In its original context, [Isa 45:23](#) is surrounded by assertions of God's sovereignty ([Isa 45:22](#), [24](#)). Only the sovereign God has the right to stand in judgment ([Rom 14:10](#), [12](#)).

Romans 14:13

This verse acts as a bridge. Let's stop condemning each other summarizes [14:1-12](#), while the concern about causing another believer to stumble and fall becomes the major emphasis of [14:14-23](#). • stumble and fall: This phrase originally applied to obstacles that could trip people as they walked, or to traps into which a person might fall. It is used metaphorically throughout the New Testament for behavior that might bring spiritual harm to another

person (see [1 Cor 8:9](#), [13](#); [1 Jn 2:10](#); cp. [Matt 21:42-44](#); [Luke 20:17-18](#); [Rom 9:32-33](#); [1 Pet 2:8](#)).

Romans 14:14

no food, in and of itself, is wrong to eat (literally *nothing is common in itself*): The word *common* signals that the root concern that Paul was addressing was Jewish purity regulations. Jews described food as *common* if it was not clean (i.e., not kosher), thereby causing a Jew to become ritually impure (see [Lev 11](#); cp. [Mark 7:2](#), [5](#); [Acts 10:14](#)). Paul again follows the teaching of Jesus that "every kind of food is acceptable in God's eyes" ([Mark 7:19](#)). • for that person it is wrong: The truth that no food is wrong to eat was not easy for pious Jews to accept because they had been raised to honor God by avoiding certain foods. Paul urges those who are strong in faith not to force others to violate their consciences (cp. [1 Cor 8:1-13](#)).

Romans 14:15

The word translated ruin (Greek *apollumi*, "destroy") is often applied to eternal damnation (see [2:12](#); [Matt 10:28](#); [18:14](#); [Luke 9:24](#); [13:2-5](#); [John 3:16](#); [10:10](#), [28](#); [1 Cor 1:18-19](#); [Jas 4:12](#); [2 Pet 3:9](#)). By insisting on their freedom to eat whatever they want, the strong might cause sensitive Jewish Christians for whom Christ died to turn away from the faith.

Romans 14:20

The work of God refers both to the spiritual life of other Christians ([14:15](#)) and to the Christian community itself ([14:19](#)). The strong, with their dogged insistence on doing whatever they want, create division and disrupt God's intention to build a healthy and united community of believers.

Romans 14:21

or drink wine: Jews sometimes abstained from wine to avoid the appearance of ritual contamination, since wine was used in pagan religious celebrations (see [Dan 1:3-16](#)).

Romans 14:22

keep it between yourself and God: Paul did not contest the freedom of the strong believers, but he instructed them to limit the expression of their freedom out of love for fellow believers so that the whole Christian community could be built up. • Blessed are those who don't feel guilty: Guilt could come from harming the faith of the weak believers. Christian freedom is only worthwhile when it can be lived out without bringing such guilt.

Romans 14:23

If you do anything you believe is not right, you are sinning: God's word defines sin for us, yet sin also involves violating our conscience. The weak Christians in Rome did not yet believe in their own hearts that they could eat meat, drink wine, or ignore Jewish holy days; their consciences were still weak. They should not violate their consciences on these matters. Nor should the strong, by the power of their example or by their scorn, force weak Christians to do so.

Romans 15:1–4

We who are strong: Paul aligns himself with those he identifies as strong in faith, and he reveals that the division in the Roman church was not simply between Jews and Gentiles. Like Paul, some Jews had enlightened consciences and so were counted among the strong. Similarly, some Gentiles were so strongly influenced by Jewish teaching and tradition that they were among the weak in faith. • must be considerate of those who are sensitive about things like this: This phrase is reminiscent of [Gal 6:2](#). Paul did not want the strong to simply put up with those who were weak in faith; rather the strong were to actively and sympathetically assist the weak in living out their Christian faith with integrity (see also [Gal 5:13–15](#)).

Romans 15:2

others (literally *the neighbor*): See [Lev 19:18](#), quoted in [Rom 13:9](#). Love for others should govern the conduct of people who are strong in faith.

Romans 15:3

This quotation is from [Ps 69:9](#). • A number of passages in the New Testament use [Psalm 69](#) to describe Jesus' suffering ([Matt 27:34](#); [Mark 15:35–36](#); [Luke 23:36](#); [John 15:25](#); [19:28–29](#)). Paul's quotation of just a small portion of that psalm evokes the whole experience of Jesus' suffering.

Romans 15:4

Such things were written in the Scriptures long ago to teach us: All that God caused to be recorded in the Old Testament has supreme relevance to believers, who experience the fulfillment of God's plan.

Romans 15:5–6

live in complete harmony: This phrase (see study note on 12:16) refers to the whole orientation of how someone thinks. A mindset of harmony is important for Christian unity (see [12:3–5](#), [16](#); [Phil 2:2–5](#)).

Romans 15:7

To accept each other means more than grudgingly putting up with each other. We are to welcome other believers, with all their flaws and sins, into our fellowship and treat them as family (see study note on 12:10), just as Christ has accepted us, with all our flaws and sins, into his fellowship and family ([5:8–11](#)).

Romans 15:8–9

Through Christ, God made it possible for Jews and Gentiles to join together to give glory to him in the new covenant people of God (see chs [9–11](#)). The issue of Jewish–Gentile relationships was fundamental to the dispute in the Roman church ([14:1–15:7](#)).

Romans 15:9–12

would join with Jews in praising God. Gentiles are now full members of God's people.

Romans 15:14

You know these things so well: Paul praises the Roman Christians, as he had in the opening of the letter (see [1:8-12](#)), demonstrating a gracious manner toward a church he had neither founded nor visited.

Romans 15:14-16:27

This final section contains elements common at the end of New Testament letters: a discussion of travel plans ([15:14-29](#)), requests for prayer ([15:30-33](#)), references to ministry associates ([16:1-2](#), [21-23](#)), greetings ([16:3-16](#)), and a doxology ([16:25-27](#)). Only the warning about false teachers ([16:17-19](#)) is a non-standard feature in this conclusion.

Romans 15:15-16

by God's grace: Paul emphasized that his role as apostle and teacher was because God had chosen him to lead in the formation of the Christian church (see also [1:5](#); [12:3](#); [1 Cor 3:10](#); [Gal 2:9](#); [Eph 3:2](#), [7](#), [8](#)).

Romans 15:16

special messenger: The Greek word (*leitourgos*, "servant" or "minister") could refer to almost any kind of servant, but Jews often applied the word to priests. Paul probably chose this word to emphasize the priestly nature of his ministry. • to you Gentiles: Paul stresses the Gentile flavor of the church in Rome (see also [1:6-7](#)). This does not mean that there were no Jews in the church (see [16:3-16](#)), but Gentiles had become the majority. • present you as an acceptable offering to God: Paul was fulfilling [Isa 66:19-20](#).

Romans 15:19

I have fully presented the Good News of Christ: Paul was not claiming that the work of evangelism had been completed in these regions. His point was that churches had been planted in enough major population centers so that those churches could carry on the work of evangelism themselves. Paul's

own distinctive ministry of planting foundational and strategic churches had been fulfilled. • An arc drawn from Jerusalem all the way to Illyricum would include the areas where Paul had planted churches (southern Galatia, Asia Minor, Macedonia, and Greece). Illyricum was a Roman province that occupied most of the coastlands northeast of Italy along the Adriatic Sea, from modern-day Albania to Croatia.

Romans 15:24

I am planning to go to Spain: In Paul's day, "Spain" included the entire Iberian Peninsula (modern Spain and Portugal). Parts of the peninsula had been occupied by the Romans since 200 BC, but only within Paul's lifetime had the area been organized into a Roman province. Paul saw Spain, at the far end of the Mediterranean, as his final target in fulfilling the promise of [Isa 66:19-20](#). • you can provide for my journey: Spain was so far from Paul's previous sending church, Antioch in Syria, that he hoped the Roman church could serve as the logistical base for this future evangelistic effort.

Romans 15:25-28

I must go to Jerusalem to take a gift to the believers there: During his third missionary journey, Paul collected donations from the Gentile churches to help the believers in Jerusalem and to draw the two wings of the first-century church closer together (see also [1 Cor 16:1-2](#); [2 Cor 8-9](#)).

Romans 15:26

Paul founded churches in several prominent cities in Macedonia, including Philippi, Thessalonica, and Berea. In Achaia, Paul had preached in Athens and founded the church in Corinth (see [Acts 16-18](#)). • the poor among the believers in Jerusalem: Jewish Christians in Jerusalem were suffering from famines that had hit the area (see [Acts 11:27-30](#)) and also because their faith in Christ caused them to be ostracized from Jewish society.

Romans 15:27

they owe a real debt: Gentile Christians owe their spiritual existence to God's work among the Israelites (see [11:17-24](#)).

Romans 15:31

Pray that I will be rescued from those in Judea who refuse to obey God: See [Acts 21-22](#). God preserved Paul's life and used the circumstances of his arrest in Jerusalem to take him precisely where he planned to go—Rome.

Romans 15:33

Some manuscripts do not include Amen. One very early manuscript places the doxology ([16:25-27](#)) here. This has led some scholars to conclude that the original letter to the Romans consisted of only [1:1-15:33](#), but few now follow this theory. The best early manuscripts place the doxology at the end of ch [16](#), and the whole of ch [16](#) was most likely part of Paul's original letter to the Romans. See also study note on 16:1-16.

Romans 16:1

A deacon (Greek diakonos, "servant") refers both to a Christian who is recognized as a servant of Christ and specifically to someone who holds the office of deacon in a particular church (see [Phil 1:1](#); [1 Tim 3:8-12](#); cp. [Acts 6:1-6](#)). • Cenchrea was located about five miles from Corinth and functioned as its port. Paul might have been writing this letter to the Romans from Corinth on a winter-long stop there near the end of his third missionary journey (see [Acts 20:2-3](#)).

Romans 16:1-16

Paul here commended and greeted twenty-seven Roman Christians, ten of whom were women. Women played important roles in the early church.

- Paul had never been to Rome, which has led to some speculation as to how he knew so many people there. One theory is that ch [16](#) was actually part of another letter that Paul sent to Ephesus. However, we have no good manuscript evidence for a separate letter (cp. study note on 15:33).

Perhaps the answer is that Paul was able to greet so many people in Rome because he had encountered them during their travels away from Rome (see Romans Book Introduction, "Setting").

Romans 16:2

she has been helpful to many: This phrase indicates the ancient role of the patron, a wealthy person who used influence and money to help people and causes. Phoebe was apparently a woman of wealth and influence who used her resources to help missionaries such as Paul.

Romans 16:3

Priscilla and Aquila were Paul's good friends. After leaving Rome around AD 49, they became his co-workers for an extended time in Corinth and Ephesus (see [Acts 18-19](#)). They had apparently returned to Rome by the time Paul wrote Romans (about AD 57).

Romans 16:3-16

Although Paul had never visited the Christian community in Rome, he established rapport with these believers by personally greeting many of the church's members. The names reveal that the Roman Christian community was very diverse—Jews and Gentiles, slaves and free, men and women all formed a new society in the church (see [Gal 3:26-29](#)).

Romans 16:5

the church that meets in their home: Early Christians did not have large buildings for their meetings—they met in private homes. The church in Rome was composed of a number of house churches where small groups of believers gathered for worship and instruction.

Romans 16:7

In Greek, the name Junia could refer to a man named *Junias* or to a woman named *Junia*. Most interpreters understand *Junia* as a feminine name. This section pairs masculine and feminine names

to refer to husband-and-wife teams, so Junia was probably a woman. • who were in prison with me: When this occurred is uncertain. According to Acts, Paul had been imprisoned overnight in Philippi ([Acts 16:19–28](#)); after Romans was written, he would later be imprisoned for two years in Caesarea ([Acts 24:27](#)) and for two years in Rome ([Acts 28:30–31](#)). Paul was undoubtedly imprisoned on occasions not mentioned in Acts (see [2 Cor 11:23](#)). • highly respected among the apostles: This phrase probably indicates that Andronicus and Junia were apostles—i.e., accredited missionaries of the church (see [Acts 14:4, 14](#); [1 Cor 9:5–6](#); [Gal 2:9](#)).

Romans 16:10

This Aristobulus was probably the same man as the brother of Herod Agrippa I; Aristobulus was a member of the Roman aristocracy who lived in Rome many years prior to his death in AD 48 or 49 (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.8.4; *War* 2.11.6). His household probably refers to his family and their servants in Rome.

Romans 16:13

This Rufus might be the individual mentioned as the son of Simon of Cyrene, who carried Christ's cross (see [Mark 15:21](#)).

Romans 16:16

with a sacred kiss: The kiss was a common way to greet another person in the ancient world and particularly among the Jews. It is mentioned frequently in the New Testament as a greeting ([1 Cor 16:20](#); [2 Cor 13:12](#); [1 Thes 5:26](#); see [1 Pet 5:14](#)); the kiss of peace became a standard feature of the Christian liturgy by the second century.

Romans 16:17

people who cause divisions: Paul had trouble with divisive false teachers elsewhere (see Galatians, Colossians, 1 Timothy), so he warned the Roman church about this danger.

Romans 16:20

The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet: Paul alludes to the curse that God pronounced upon the serpent after he had deceived Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden ([Gen 3:15](#)). Christ, the offspring of Eve, will soon crush Satan under the feet of the church (cp. [Matt 16:18–19](#)).

Romans 16:21

Timothy was one of Paul's closest ministry associates. Timothy accompanied Paul on his second missionary journey ([Acts 16:2–3](#)) and was with Paul in Corinth while Paul wrote this letter to the Roman church (see [Acts 20:2–4](#)).

Romans 16:22

Tertius was the scribe (or *amanuensis*) who wrote the letter as Paul dictated. Most ancient letter writers employed such a scribe.

Romans 16:23

This Erastus was probably the individual Paul sent from Ephesus to Macedonia during his third missionary journey ([Acts 19:21–22](#); see [2 Tim 4:20](#)). An inscription in Corinth mentions an Erastus who was a city magistrate, possibly the same Erastus mentioned here.

Romans 16:25

plan (literally *mystery*): For Paul, the *mystery* is the truth about God and his plan that was not clearly known in the Old Testament era but which has been revealed in the New Testament era. While the Old Testament predicted the conversion of Gentiles, it did not make clear that Gentiles would become equal members of the people of God without becoming proselytes of Judaism.

Romans 16:25–27

This doxology makes a very appropriate conclusion to Paul's letter and its argument, reprising many of the themes found at the very beginning ([1:1–15](#)). • The doxology is missing in

two late manuscripts and is in different places in other manuscripts (after [14:23](#) and after [15:33](#)). Therefore, these verses might have been added to Paul's letter at a later time. However, the majority of manuscripts do include the doxology at the end of the letter, and it uses vocabulary and themes common in the rest of the letter. Paul most likely wrote it himself as a conclusion to the letter.

Romans 16:26

so that they too might believe and obey him: Paul uses the same language about the mission to the Gentiles that he used in [1:5](#), creating a beautiful frame around the letter as a whole.